they were supported by the Pakistan Army (specifically the Inter-Services Intelligence agency). However, both the ISI and the madrasahs denied these links (see several issues of Wafaq ul Madaris), and therefore, it could not be ascertained as to how many madrasahs had increased by the financial aid provided by foreign donors or the Pakistan Army (Rehman, 2004).

In the first years of Zia's Islamisation (1979–82), only 151 new madrasahs were established, but in the next six years, another 1,000 were established. According to an official estimate in 1995, a total of 2,010 new madrasahs had been registered since 1979, the majority affiliated with the Deobandis, although Ahl-e-Hadith madrasahs also grew significantly. Reflecting rising sectarianism, Shi'a madrasahs grew similarly, from 70 in 1979 to 116 in 1983–4.

Madrasahs were crucial for mobilising opinion and recruiting and training militants for the anti-Soviet jihad of the 1980s. The JI's Jamiat Talaba Arabia (JTA) madrasahs and the JUI's Deobandi madrasahs were particularly fertile grounds. The two factions of Jamiat Ulema-e-Islam (JUI) constituted more than 65 per cent of all madrasahs, mainly in the Pashtun-majority KP and the Pashtun belt of Balochistan, from which the majority of their party workers and leaders graduated. In Punjab, there were approximately 10,068 madaris in 2012. The break-up was as follows: Deobandi – 4,350; Barelvi – 4,843; Ahl-e-Hadith – 663 and Shi'a – 212.[6] The increase in the number of registered madrasahs was outstanding: from 2,002 in 1988 to 9,880 in 2002. The Deobandi madrasahs, the ones most closely allied to the Taliban, had increased in number from 1,779 to more than 7,000.

P.W. Singer gave the estimate of 45,000 madrasahs but did not quote any source for this number (Rehman, 2004).

According to the International Crisis Group (ICG) report:

> The Haqqania madrasah graduated 3,000 students each year, who left with one central lesson: to carry out jihad in the name of Islam. Those from influential families often go into politics, while those with limited economic prospects were encouraged to join militant groups, teach at Deobandi madrasahs or open new madrasahs.
>
> To the best of my knowledge, there was hardly any evidence that these students were encouraged to join militant groups. It was